

What evaluation questions should be asked about an initiative at each point in the 'social-problem solving cycle'?

No one wants social problems to continue indefinitely, and if they can be fixed without causing difficulties for key stakeholders, then they usually are. However, as the Social Problem Cycle Tool (E18) highlights, a number of social problems tend to continue on without being solved because some key stakeholders end up resisting particular strategies and styles of action in spite of them being the most effective approaches to take.

Evaluation can play an important role in providing information at key points in the social problem cycle, which can then help ensure that more effective, although harder to get implemented strategies, are used. Right at the start of an initiative, developmental evaluation can help to make sure that the problem that an initiative is focusing on is defined in a way that will enable it to significantly impact the social problem. Formative evaluation can be used to optimize the strategies being used in the initiative, for instance, by comparing the initiative's proposed strategies and those in the Initiative or Policy Strategy Selection Tool (B10) and the Social Problem Strategies Continuum (G18).

Process evaluation can be used to identify the dynamics that are playing out regarding the initiative as it is being implemented and whether it is being supported to deploy the most effective strategies, regardless of whether there is resistance from some stakeholder groups impacted by them.

Impact evaluation can then be used to identify whether any initiative is actually making a difference to the social problem it is attempting to improve. The Priority Types of Evaluation at Each Point in the Social Problem Cycle Tool (G20) shows where different types of evaluation can add value at different points in the playing out of the cycle.